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Migration and Development

> ‘An ideal society should be mobile, should be full of channels for conveying a change taking place in one part to other parts.’
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> —Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar[1]

Ambedkar’s view on migration was deeply conditioned by his own experience, of breaking away from the traditional shackles of caste in India, earning respect and dignity while studying at Columbia University and London School of Economics, and his numerous travels. For him, migration was intimately linked with his personal development and aspirations. He famously called the Indian village a ‘sink of localism, a den of ignorance, narrow-mindedness and communalism’.[2] In contrast, Gandhi, who had lived outside India for over two decades, celebrated village life and shunned modern cities. He considered the ‘growth of cities as an evil thing, unfortunate for mankind and the world’.[3] A third character in 20th century Indian politics—Bal Thackeray (1926–2012)—viewed migration as a potential source of conflict with native interests. While he was born in Pune, it is significant that he spent nearly his entire life in Mumbai, a city whose name he got changed.

Ambedkar and Thackeray reflect two ends of the spectrum between cosmopolitanism and nativism. The widely-travelled cosmopolitan